

ments. But I decided to stop working and get on with a new phase of my life. I'd earned my fair share. However, I'd seen enough compulsive gamblers in Las Vegas to know that the house will take back what you've won and more than even the score. I became convinced that my decision wasn't irresponsible or degenerate. I simply wanted more time to myself before it was too late to get out. I wanted a good life, not a good job.

In our society it's considered normal to work during the best years of your life. You work when you're young, healthy, and vital. You work when your mental powers are sharp, your mind inquisitive. You work when you still have a family at home and your kids need you the most. You give the best years of your life to your career and the last few years to yourself.

Are we crazy or what?

When we get to be a broken-down 62, or even a healthy 62, we retire. We finally begin a life we can call our own. We buy a Hilton Head condo, sign up a Mayo Clinic doctor, and talk shop with a clique of retirement-ghetto friends.

You don't *have* to resign yourself to that kind of fate. You can discover in your 30s or 40s that you've got more going for you than the upward spiral that so often ends in messy divorce, with kids, shiny cars, adult toys, and a country home as bargaining chips.

A long time ago we had no choice but to work a lifetime. Things were simpler then. A man worked fifty or sixty hours a week, from age 15 to the day he died, and earned barely enough to support his family. Cars were American, field-goal kickers had last names you could pronounce, and three-hour phone calls to Europe were only a glint in some crazy person's eye.

Today's M.B.A.s, lawyers, and high-tech scientists earn megabucks from the start. Even after discounting for inflation, what you earn in a few years is more than grandpa and grandma spent in their entire lives. Work fifteen or twenty